inequalities, that their relatively lower level in the future implies the persistence of mass discontentment and impoverishment in a world where the communications revolution has now made it possible for even the world's poor to know how deprived they are, despite the presence of great wealth in their own societies. It was comparative dissatisfactions rather than absolute levels of economic deprivation that helped fatally undermine the Soviet system. In the South, both relative deprivation and absolute immiseration are in all probability going to persist widely enough, thereby making possibilities of intra-South cooperation more difficult, as well as being a source for anger to erupt against ruling elites – witness the 'Arab uprisings' of recent times.

The historical pattern of capitalist industrialisation in the West and Japan was accompanied by the kind of urbanisation and employment generation there that led to the decline of the rural population to the point that it constitutes, at most, between 2% to 8% of the overall population in the advanced countries. For countries like Brazil, India, China and Mexico the rural population is currently a majority. In due course this may well become a minority, but a significant one well above the proportions now prevailing in the earlier industrialising countries. Even in those countries of the South where urbanisation has been proportionately greater than in the above-mentioned four, what has emerged and will in all likelihood continue, if not deepen, is the rise of an informal sector comprising a very large part of an urban slum population, itself growing. The ICT revolution has been a major factor in reducing the employment elasticities of output worldwide. Rising capital intensity even in agriculture means higher levels of unemployment everywhere and of low productivity, low pay employment, of more part-time work, longer working hours, greater job insecurities and thus a greater proportion than ever of the working poor.

The history of the development of an organised and unionised labour force in Western Europe as the accompaniment of its particular pattern of capitalist modernisation, and even the lower levels of such organisation of the labour force in North America and Japan, are unlikely to be replicated in BRICS, let alone elsewhere in the South. The objective conditions for much greater worker unrest in this part of the world are being laid. Grassroots organisation in slums and in local communities rather than simply at the workplace will become more important and, with this, the necessity of taking up a diversity of issues such as race, ethnicity, gender and skills difference to generate more composite forms of unity in action. While urban-based struggles over the 'right to the city', i.e. the right of the majority of urban residents to shape their lives in ways that promote meaningful cooperation and control over daily existence, are going to become